

MedAssist SLM Stakeholder Engagement Plan

Project: Domain-Specific Small Language Model for Medical Advice

Program: TRI-AI Google DeepMind Research Foundation

Purpose

MedAssist SLM operates in a high-stakes healthcare context, so stakeholder engagement is essential to ensure that the system reflects real needs, experiences, risks, and values.

Engagement will help the team identify assumptions, uncover potential harms, validate intended use cases, and improve the relevance, safety, transparency, and accessibility of the system.

Key Stakeholders

Stakeholder	Why They Matter	Engagement Focus	Method
Patients & general health-information seekers	Potential end users of general medical information.	Information needs, trust, usability, accessibility, concerns about AI.	Consultation / User testing
Caregivers & families	May seek health information on behalf of others.	Safety, information gaps, escalation needs, clarity.	Consultation
Healthcare professionals	Provide clinical and safety expertise.	Clinical relevance, source quality, unsafe response patterns, system boundaries, evaluation.	Expert review
Medical students & trainees	Potential educational users and evaluators.	Learning clarity, traceability, misconceptions, usefulness.	Consultation / Testing
Community representatives	Represent local needs, context, and healthcare access barriers.	Healthcare access, cultural context, trust, inclusion, unintended effects.	Community conversations
AI/ML researchers & engineers	Support technical design and responsible deployment.	Model limitations, datasets, retrieval, evaluation, safety, deployment.	Collaboration

Mentors & TRI-AI facilitators	Provide research, methodology, and responsible-AI guidance.	Problem framing, scope, methodology, evaluation, responsible AI.	Mentor discussions
--	---	--	--------------------

Engagement Objectives

The stakeholder engagement process aims to:

- Understand the needs and expectations of intended users and affected communities.
- Identify technical, social, cultural, and safety risks that the development team may overlook.
- Validate whether the proposed use cases and system boundaries are appropriate.
- Improve response relevance, clarity, accessibility, and safety.
- Identify representation gaps in the medical knowledge sources used by the system.
- Create a transparent feedback loop so stakeholder concerns can influence project decisions.

Engagement Methods

The team will use a combination of:

- Mentor discussions
- Healthcare-expert review
- Community conversations
- Structured user testing
- Feedback forms and questionnaires
- Dataset and source review
- Technical review sessions

Different engagement methods will be selected according to the stakeholder's expertise, role, and the sensitivity of the topic being discussed.

Key Questions for Stakeholders

During engagement, the team will explore questions such as:

1. What health-information needs are currently difficult to meet?
2. What would make an AI health-information tool trustworthy or untrustworthy?
3. Which types of responses could be unsafe or easily misunderstood?
4. Are the system's disclaimers, boundaries, and escalation messages clear?
5. How important is source attribution and traceability?
6. Which populations, languages, healthcare contexts, or experiences may be underrepresented?
7. What unintended effects could arise if users rely heavily on the system?
8. What should the system explicitly refuse to answer?
9. What would make users more comfortable verifying AI-generated health information?

Privacy, Consent, and Participant Safety

Stakeholder engagement should not require participants to disclose private medical histories.

The team will:

- Collect only information necessary for the engagement activity.
- Clearly explain the purpose of the engagement and how feedback will be used.
- Avoid collecting identifiable health information unless there is a clear ethical justification.
- Anonymize feedback where appropriate.
- Ensure participation is voluntary.
- Avoid using personal medical information as training data without appropriate ethical, privacy, and legal safeguards.

The goal is to learn from stakeholder experiences without creating unnecessary privacy risks.

How Stakeholder Feedback Will Influence the Project

Stakeholder feedback will be used to refine:

- Intended use cases
- Dataset selection
- Medical source priorities
- Safety and refusal boundaries
- Evaluation scenarios
- Language and accessibility considerations
- User experience
- Deployment assumptions
- Documentation of limitations

Feedback from healthcare professionals and affected communities concerning potentially harmful use cases will receive particular attention during safety and evaluation reviews.

Feedback & Accountability Log

The team will maintain a stakeholder feedback log to ensure that engagement results in concrete project decisions.

Stakeholder Group	Date	Concern / Feedback	Project Response	Decision
-------------------	------	--------------------	------------------	----------

Decision options:

- Adopted
- Partially Adopted
- Not Adopted

Where feedback is not adopted, the team should document the reason.

Engagement Principles

Respect

Treat participants' experiences, knowledge, and concerns seriously.

Inclusion

Seek perspectives from people who may be affected by the system, not only technical experts.

Transparency

Clearly communicate what MedAssist can and cannot do.

Safety First

Prioritize preventing harmful use over maximizing the apparent capability of the system.

Evidence-Informed Decisions

Consider stakeholder feedback alongside clinical evidence, technical evidence, and evaluation results.

Continuous Engagement

Treat stakeholder input as an ongoing part of development and evaluation rather than a one-time activity.

Expected Outcome

The intended outcome is a MedAssist SLM that is more relevant to its users, safer in high-risk health contexts, transparent about its limitations, and responsive to community and expert concerns.

Stakeholder engagement will directly inform the project's dataset, safety boundaries, evaluation strategy, user experience, and documentation of limitations.